

Black Diamond: An Essay in Left-Hand Path Philosophy

Abstract. This essay derives a theory of will from a single operation — distinction. Consciousness, the only epistemic given, operates through distinction; all further categories (code, aspect, causality, energy, attractor) follow without external ontological commitments. Causality is reinterpreted as a spectrum of rigidity in the linkage between codes, with acausality shown to be formally primary: any causal linkage is a restriction within the wider field of unrestricted combinability. The attractor, a self-reinforcing configuration of codes distributed across aspects of consciousness, is analyzed as the mechanism by which will becomes captured through cross-aspect recruitment and autopoietic closure. Two independent properties of will are identified: strength (holding a code under pressure) and flexibility (releasing it without collapse). Antinomianism is the systematic training of flexibility. The Black Diamond names the condition where both operate at full capacity — the practical foundation of the Left-Hand Path.

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1. Distinction

Every claim about the world passes through a single bottleneck: it is made by a conscious subject. The stone exists, the law holds, God watches — each assertion is produced within consciousness and has never been verified from outside it. No human being has ever stepped beyond perception to check whether the perceived matches something independent. The check itself would be an act of perception.

The phrase "objective world" (a reality persisting without observers) names something no one has observed. It may exist. The claim of its existence, however, occupies the same epistemic format as any other assertion about what lies beyond consciousness. A subject who declares "matter exists independently of me" and a subject who declares "God exists" perform the same operation: both produce a statement within consciousness and assign it the status of something beyond mind. Neither claim can be verified, because verification would require a vantage point outside the only vantage point available. This is not solipsism; the point is that every assertion about what exists is made from within the subject and cannot escape this condition.

What consciousness does, in every instance, is distinguish. A border is drawn: this against that, now against then. Without the border, nothing is registered. Drawing the boundaries requires at minimum retention (something must hold both sides) and comparison (the sides must be found different). These operations are already reflexive: the subject holds its own prior state and measures the present against it. Distinction, retention, and comparison are inseparable. Where one is absent, the others collapse, and nothing is given.

An attempt to think without distinction would need to distinguish itself from thinking-with-distinction. The exit is sealed from within. Whatever consciousness touches, it engages through this operation. The question worth asking is: what follows from the fact that distinction is the only available operation?

A point on a white surface exists insofar as it differs from the background. Without distinction the background and the point are indiscernible, and any assertion of the point's existence lacks content.

Distinction always occurs within an *aspect*. The point differs from the surrounding area in color, in shape, and in size. Each aspect provides a dimension along which distinction is drawn. Perceptual aspects, such

as color, sound or shape, provide dimensions along which distinction is drawn.

Distinction has *intensity*. A red point on a white background is distinguished more sharply than a light gray one. Intensity is the degree to which a distinction is pronounced within a given aspect.

Space is the stable organization of distinctions across several dimensions at once — intensity, boundary, and co-presence. A nearby object is not always distinguished more sharply than a remote one; a bright star outstrips the hand in front of the face. What produces spatial structure is the configuration of these dimensions taken together: the way boundaries relate to intensities, the way co-present objects constrain each other's positions. Distance emerges within this configuration as one of its stable parameters.

Time is the order of acts of distinction. Each act of distinguishing occupies a position relative to other acts. Lightning flashes, then thunder follows. The ordering of these two acts constitutes a temporal sequence. Time does not contain distinctions; it is constituted by their ordering. Where no new act of distinction occurs, no temporal interval is produced.

A distinction drawn in one aspect can be *projected* onto another. Such a projection creates a *code*. A tall branching object in the field of perception is projected onto language as the word "tree." The code retains the distinction in a different medium — it can be communicated, stored, and recombined without the original perceptual act. Spatial relations are projected onto time: a distant object becomes a "long time away." Temperature is mapped onto emotion: a person is described as "warm." A distinction native to one aspect is carried into another, producing a code that operates in the target aspect while referring to the source.

Horizontal projection thickens an aspect without changing its medium. A physicist describes a falling stone in Newtonian terms;

another reformulates the same event through Lagrangian mechanics. The phenomenon is unchanged, the mathematical aspect is unchanged, but a different region of the same domain has been activated. The aspect grows denser. Its boundaries do not move.

Vertical projection generates a new aspect. When distinction turns upon itself, the result belongs to a different order.

A tree enters the visual field. The perceptual code registers shape, color, and distance. Then something shifts: unease, or attraction, or blankness. This response targets the percept itself — evaluating it along a dimension absent from vision. Emotion has appeared: the subject has distinguished its reaction to the percept, and the reaction has become a code in its own right.

Close your eyes, and the tree persists as an image. The stimulus is withdrawn; the code survives in its absence. Imagination opens: a domain where codes operate without referents.

Two images held side by side reveal something shared: both rise vertically, branch at the top, and taper. Extracting this pattern requires an operation on the representations themselves. Thought has appeared — and with it the aspect of reason, where codes relate to other codes through extracted invariances.

A philosopher catches himself reaching for mechanical metaphors before any other kind. The observation targets the way reasoning selects its tools. Here the aspect of worldview is revealed: the total configuration that determines which directions of projection the subject defaults to, which codes feel trustworthy before evaluation begins.

What begins as a seen tree becomes an unease, then an image held after the eyes close, then a pattern shared with other forms, then a preference for certain patterns over others. Each step applies distinction to the products of the prior step.

Every domain opened by inward recursion is an aspect — a dimension along which distinctions are drawn, no different in operation from color or sound. A subject feels a desire and then judges it: this impulse is worth following, and that one should be suppressed. The judgment turns the recursive operation upon the will's own orientation. Value is the aspect that emerges here. Morality formalizes values into a shared system — permitted and prohibited, obligation and transgression. A moral code constrains acts of will the way grammar constrains sentences. The penalty for moral deviation is guilt.

2. Causality

Causality is a stabilized projection of regularity between aspects. In its most primitive form (a foot striking a stone) the regularity links spatial contact to a temporal sequence: because the foot and stone met, pain followed. Hume's observation holds at this level: we perceive contiguity and succession and project a necessary link between them.

Beyond direct contact, causality operates through wider channels. Radiation damages tissue without touching it in any ordinary spatial sense. A legal precedent set decades ago constrains a verdict today — the linkage runs through institutional memory, not through proximity. A rumor circulates through a network and collapses a stock price; the causal chain passes through information. In each case a regularity between aspects has been stabilized to the point where the projection appears necessary, even though the aspects involved differ from case to case.

What unites these cases is the degree of rigidity. At the perceptual level, rigidity is maximal — the apparatus locks the projection and the subject cannot override it.

Different perceptual apparatuses register different distinctions. An organism that senses electromagnetic fields directly draws distinctions invisible to a pressure-based apparatus — and from them different

causal chains follow. It does not contradict the physics available to the pressure-sensing observer; it accesses regularities that the other apparatus cannot register at all. Whether anything remains beyond every possible apparatus is a question we cannot answer from within.

At the level of codes, this rigidity dissolves. Consider the statement "killing is wrong." The code "killing" is linked to the code "wrong." Does this linkage obey a law comparable to the foot striking the stone? Another subject links "killing" to "necessary," a third to "sacred," and a fourth to "inevitable." Each linkage has a local basis — a context and a purpose. No global law governs which code attaches to which.

Oil prices rise by thirty percent. A financial analyst codes the event as an opportunity. Across the desk, the same chart produces a crisis. A televangelist, reading the same headline, delivers a third: divine correction for a wasteful civilization. The price data constrains all three — the numbers narrow the field of admissible readings. The same number nevertheless sustains incompatible evaluations, keeping it well below the perceptual threshold where projection is locked.

Causality, then, is the degree of rigidity with which a projection between aspects is maintained. At the perceptual level, rigidity is maximal — projections are locked in by the apparatus and appear as natural law. At higher recursive levels — language, value, worldview — rigidity disappears. The projection continues, but the linkage is no longer fixed. What we call *acausality* is the absence of a global law governing the connection in the presence of local grounds that vary by subject.

The perceptual world itself is a projection. What appears as a solid object is a product of thresholds enforced by the apparatus. Below a certain intensity, a difference is suppressed; above it, it is registered as a boundary. The boundary becomes the object. In Kantian terms, the apparatus projects the thing-in-itself onto the aspects available to it — and the projection is all that reaches consciousness. The thing-in-itself

persists as whatever produces the differences the apparatus registers. But its form, boundaries, and identity belong to the projection, not to the source. Under mescaline, color distinctions intensify while boundaries between objects soften. A chair and the wall behind it, ordinarily separated by a hard contour, begin to bleed into each other. The edge that defined "chair" as an object was a cutoff imposed by the apparatus — a parameter, not a property of the thing perceived. Differences previously filtered out now surface, and the perceptual scene reorganizes: more color, fewer objects. What the subject briefly glimpses is the threshold itself revealed as a setting of the apparatus rather than a feature of the world.

3. Acausality and the Black Flame

The sentence "the cat flies" links two codes. So does "the cat sepulks" — a verb with no referent in any known language. Physical reality excludes flying cats; the coding operation itself admits any combination. "Justice is blue." "Time weighs seven kilograms." Each performs a projection. The operation encounters no obstacle.

This unrestricted combinability is the defining feature of codes above the perceptual level. Any code can be projected onto any aspect.

The capacity to select the aspect of projection freely is the source of acausality in the domain of codes. Where this capacity is absent, projection is locked: the perceptual apparatus channels it into a narrow range and produces causal regularity. Where it is present, the same content receives different codes depending on the direction of projection.

We designate this capacity as *the Black Flame*. It is the freedom of projection — the fact that the distinguishing act can redirect itself without external authorization. Every instance of creative recoding, reinterpretation, or conceptual invention is an exercise of this capacity.

Acausality is formally primary. Unrestricted combinability of codes is the wider field; any stabilized causal linkage is a restriction within it. A fixed connection between two codes ("this cause produces this effect") is one possibility among the full set of projections available. Acausality generates causality by narrowing. Every causal law occupies a single path through a space that admits all paths.

Causality as the rigid, invariant linkage between input and output appears only where projection has been locked in by the apparatus. Any increase in the flexibility of projection moves the subject closer to the primary condition. Altered states and antinomian acts are partial restorations of the order that preceded the restriction.

4. Energy

A subject cuts down a tree and builds a house. The tree was a biological formation the subject did not produce. The available tools, the physical properties of wood, and the force required to fell the trunk — all are constraints inherited from stabilized distinctions preceding the subject. Within these constraints, the subject draws new distinctions: here a wall, there a window. Once the house stands, these distinctions are fixed. The next inhabitant encounters them as givens — walls that cannot be walked through, doors that channel movement. The builder's act of distinction has become the inhabitant's constraint.

Energy is a distinction viewed from the side of those who did not draw it. Every act of distinction that stabilizes becomes energy for subsequent distinguishers.

DNA carries the same logic into biology. A nucleotide sequence encodes distinctions accumulated across millions of years of selection. An organism born today inherits this code without having authored any of it. The genetic code constrains the organism the way a legal code constrains the citizen: prior acts of distinction, sedimented and

transmitted, shaping what the next distinguisher can do within their field.

The external world, as the perceptual apparatus encounters it, is energy throughout. The stone's hardness is a distinction drawn long before the hand that touches it. Gravitational pull is a distinction whose author is inaccessible but whose constraint is immediate. Every prior act of distinction that has stabilized into a permanent condition operates as energy for those who come after: it shapes perception, movement, and the codes available to those who follow.

At any moment, the world is layered energy. What one generation distinguished and held, the next inherits as a given — no longer experienced as someone's act, but as the way things are.

5. Attractor

Energy is distinction shaped externally. An *attractor* is a distinction established within the subject's own aspects of consciousness. A moral conviction held so firmly that questioning it produces guilt before the question is even formulated — this is a stabilized code operating as a constraint on further acts of distinction from within.

The mechanism of stabilization is projection across aspects. A moral code ("honesty is paramount") begins in the aspect of value. It projects onto emotion: dishonesty produces guilt. The guilt recruits reasoning — arguments against absolute honesty begin to feel weak, while those in favor carry immediate force. Once reasoning has been captured, worldview follows: people divide into honest and dishonest, and facial expressions are scanned for signs of deceit before a word has been spoken. At each step, the code colonizes a new aspect and recruits its resources. The result is a configuration in which multiple aspects simultaneously reinforce the same distinction. This self-reinforcing configuration is the *attractor*.

An attractor defends itself through the convergence it has produced. A challenge to the value ("sometimes honesty is cruel") is met by the emotion (guilt at the very thought), the reasoning (counterarguments arrive immediately), and the worldview (the challenger is classified as dishonest). The subject experiences this as conviction. From outside, the structure is visible: the code has arranged the aspects so that each one blocks challenges arriving through any other.

An attractor that has penetrated all of the subject's aspects constitutes what may be called an *ontovirus*: a code so thoroughly distributed across aspects that no single aspect provides a foothold from which to question it. The subject enclosed in such a configuration cannot locate a position from which the code manifests as code. It appears instead as reality.

An attractor produces a basin around itself — a region within which the will, once entered, is pulled toward the attractor's center. Any position inside the basin leads back to the same configuration: doubts resolve into the same conviction, challenges strengthen rather than weaken it. The threshold for entering the basin is lower than the threshold for exiting it. Adopting a moral conviction requires modest initial agreement; abandoning it involves overcoming the entire cross-aspect reinforcement that has accumulated since adoption. Exit is disproportionately hard. This *hysteresis* explains why deabsolutization — the recognition that a code is a code — demands more force than the original absolutization.

In a system of interlocking attractors, each code supports the thresholds of its neighbors. Removing one code destabilizes the local configuration, but the surrounding attractors respond by restoring the missing element or compensating for its absence. This is *autopoietic* closure. The ontovirus regenerates its components. Isolated acts of questioning rarely produce lasting change: the ecology of codes repairs the disruption.

Ashby's law states that a regulator must possess at least as many states as the system it governs. Dismantling an attractor requires a repertoire of operations at least as complex as the attractor's defense structure. A single contrary argument directed against a code reinforced across five aspects will fail — the argument lacks sufficient variety to engage all layers of reinforcement simultaneously.

6. Will and the Black Diamond

An act of distinction involves a selection — this boundary, at this threshold, in this aspect. The selection has a direction. "The tree is timber" rather than "the tree is sacred." The direction is not determined by the codes themselves — no global law governs which code attaches to which. *Will* is the act by which a distinction is maintained, released, or redirected. It is therefore not inferred from the content of distinctions but from the fact that distinctions can be held otherwise.

A painter stands before an untouched canvas. Everything is prepared, and nothing in the arrangement dictates the first stroke. Years of practice narrow the range but a repertoire of admissible moves remains open, and the repertoire does not decide among its entries. Something picks this line at this angle over every other admissible stroke. The picking is the will.

The question "why this distinction rather than another" receives different answers depending on the level of rigidity. At the perceptual level, the answer is largely causal: the apparatus determines the output. At the level of codes, the answer is local: the subject has grounds (purposes, contexts, histories) but no law compels the selection. The grounds explain without necessitating. A different will, in the same situation, with the same context, may draw a different distinction.

Most acts of distinction are directed by attractors already in place. The subject who codes a political event as a threat does so because a prior configuration of values and worldview channels the projection before deliberation begins. The will is present — it supplies the force — but the direction has been set by the attractor. Free selection of the aspect of projection occurs only where the will has not been captured or where it has regained the capacity to override the attractor's pull.

Strength of will is the capacity to maintain a distinction against resistance. An ascetic who holds a fast for forty days demonstrates strength: the code "I do not eat" is sustained against the continuous pressure of hunger. A dogmatist exhibits the same quality in a different register: the code "this is true" is sustained against counterargument and ridicule. Strength is the force with which any single configuration is held.

A strong will inside an attractor uses its strength to hold the attractor in place. The basin deepens with every act of commitment. Strength serves the code. The will becomes indistinguishable from its configuration, and removing the code would mean collapse — the will has no organization apart from the order it adopted.

We call this delegation of will. The code determines the direction; the will supplies the force. The subject still acts — often with great intensity — but the selection of what to perceive and how to respond has been outsourced to the attractor. Delegation is invisible to the one who has delegated: from inside the basin, the code's directions feel like one's own choices.

Attractors vary in depth. A musical preference is a shallow attractor — it channels listening but yields without resistance when challenged. A political identity runs deeper: it organizes perception of events, filters social bonds, and triggers emotional responses to headlines before the content has been read. A religious worldview that has penetrated every aspect from emotional life to the perception of death is an attractor so

total that the subject cannot locate a single aspect from which to question it. The deeper the attractor, the more aspects it has colonized, and the more completely the will has been delegated.

Flexibility of will is measured by the ability to hold a position with full force and then, when the situation demands it, adopt the opposing position with equal force. The first move depends on strength. The second requires the capacity to release what was held without the release collapsing the will that held it.

Antinomianism — the systematic violation of stabilized codes — serves as training in flexibility. Each antinomian act targets a specific attractor: identifies the code, locates the threshold at which it enforces compliance, and deliberately crosses it. The threshold is exposed as set rather than given. The code, momentarily deactivated, reveals the aspect it occupied — and the will discovers that the aspect persists without the code. The exercise is the controlled practice of releasing attractors, building the capacity to operate without fixed codes when required.

Two failures recur. The first is inversion: the negation of a code hardens into a code of its own. Compassion was the attractor; cruelty replaces it and occupies the basin with the same rigidity. The second is incomplete dismantling: the code is shaken but not fully released, and the attractor's autopoietic structure repairs the damage. Both failures leave the will inside the basin it intended to exit.

Deabsolutization is the cognitive operation at the core of antinomianism: the moment at which a distinction that appeared to be a feature of reality is identified as a product of will. Deabsolutization does not destroy the code. It changes the relation between will and code. The code remains available; it is no longer compulsory. The will can hold it or replace it, transitioning from an opaque code, experienced as reality, to a transparent one: held deliberately, used instrumentally, and discardable without structural collapse.

Deabsolutization does not advance evenly across all aspects at once. A subject who has identified moral codes as codes may remain fully captured by an aesthetic attractor — or by a political one, or by a metaphysical commitment so deeply embedded that it registers as perception rather than belief. Each attractor requires its own dismantling. The work is a continuing expansion of the zone within which codes are held deliberately rather than undergone.

What remains when deabsolutization has been applied across all aspects? The codes do not vanish — a subject without codes cannot distinguish at all. They change status: each code is held by the will rather than holding the will. The subject operates within moral codes and conceptual frameworks — but none of them serve as attractors. None have colonized neighboring aspects and none are mistaken for reality. The will moves through codes the way a hand moves through tools: picking up what the task requires, setting it down when the task is done.

This brings us to the *Black Diamond*: maximal strength combined with maximal flexibility. The Black Diamond is strength that operates in every direction. A rigid will is strong along one axis — remove that axis and it collapses. The Black Diamond holds any configuration with full force and releases it at will. The name refers to hardness without a fixed shape.

A will frozen in attractors borrows its coherence from the stability of those attractors. Remove the codes and the will collapses. A will trained across all directions of projection carries its coherence independently of any particular configuration. It holds itself.

The difference becomes decisive where external codes are absent. Any domain lacking the regularities that perception and culture supply is uninhabitable for a rigid will — its codes find no correspondence, its projections meet no surface. The flexible will does not arrive with a fixed configuration expecting correspondence. It generates a code,

tests it against what it finds, and replaces it the moment the code fails to hold. Its coherence lies in the capacity to generate codes as fast as the domain demands. Where the rigid will shatters against the absence of structure, the flexible will produces structure from its own act.

Conclusion

The Left-Hand Path rests on two strategies. Antinomianism dismantles attractors that have captured the will — each deliberate violation of a stabilized code exposes the code as contingent and returns the aspect it occupied to the subject's disposal. Flexibility is the capacity that antinomianism trains: the ability to hold any code with force, operate within it, and withdraw when the code no longer serves.

Together they produce a will that has not delegated its direction to any external configuration. Any code — moral, doctrinal, metaphysical — may be entered and used. None is compulsory. The subject who reaches this condition does not float in empty freedom. The Black Diamond holds its coherence. Where a delegated will borrows structure from the codes it serves, this will generates its own order and can do so in any domain, including those where no prior codes exist to lean on.

Every system that promises the subject a ground asks for the same payment: delegate your will, and receive certainty in return. The ground may be called God or matter or history — the transaction is identical. The Left-Hand Path is the refusal of that exchange.